

DEFENCE / **FIGHTER JETS**

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AFTER THE US UNVEILS ITS SIXTH-GEN F-47 AND CHINA PUSHES AHEAD WITH PROTOTYPES TO REDEFINE AERIAL WARFARE, **INDIA IS RACING AGAINST TIME TO FIELD A FIFTH-GEN STEALTH FIGHTER** AND MODERNISE ITS AIR FORCE

By Pradip R. Sagar

ON MARCH 21, THE UNITED STATES UNVEILED ITS SIXTH-GENERATION FIGHTER JET, the Boeing F-47, under the Next Generation Air Dominance (NGAD) programme. Announced by President Donald Trump from the Oval Office, this milestone positions the US as the first nation to field a sixth-gen fighter, with deployment targeted by the end of this decade. Designed to replace the fifth-gen F-22 Raptor, the F-47 features cutting-edge technologies, including a more efficient and high-thrust engine for supercruise, stealth enhancements and integration with Artificial Intelligence (AI). With plans for 200 jets paired with 1,000 combat drones, the NGAD programme reflects a shift toward a "system of systems" approach, prioritising long-range engagement and battlefield adaptability over traditional dogfighting.

For India, this development couldn't have come at a more precarious moment. While the world's major powers prepare for sixth-generation aerial warfare, New Delhi remains locked in a desperate struggle to field its first fifth-gen fighter, the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA). The Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA)—the nodal body for the AMCA's develop-